

WARDS BREWERY EDITED

Travel Radio Australia, we are in the beautiful region of Gladstone this month and we're at a fantastic special place called Ward's Brewery. It's a brew pub right here in the centre of Gladstone and Michael Connelly, the owner, welcome to the program. Hello Geoff, how are you? Great to see you.

Now Michael, you're a real local here in Gladstone. You actually grew up in the house next door to this brewery. Tell us about your early background and a bit about Ward's in general.

I don't want to go into too much detail Geoff, I was a bit of a reprobate as a child. But yes, I grew up in the house next door. The house is known as the Quink, Q-U-I-N-K.

It must be in excess of 100 years old. The owner of the house also owned the soft drink factory and that's where the brewery's situated. In this old soft drink factory, known as Ward's Court, it was all Ward's Soft Drink.

It had two names. So mum and dad bought that in 1974. It's actually had three owners in the last 100 odd years.

The Ward family set it up back in 1922 on this site and then the Crawfords bought it off them in 1966. My family, my mum and dad, bought Ward's Court Eels in 1974. So I grew up when it was a functioning soft drink factory.

It was well before health and safety. There was glass flying everywhere, there were bottles and all sorts of things going on. It was all timber crate stuff and I suppose going into the 80s, a perfect storm was there with plastic bottles, post mix.

Australia started discovering big shopping centres and that's when you know Woolworths and Coles really hit the injection on expansion. So everybody started buying one litre, seven up bottles and plastic bottles and things like that. So all around Australia, soft drink factories that were part of the community all died a bit of a death.

So fortunately my mum and dad owned the buildings. They put another business in here which was a car rental business and it was very successful. They held on to the company but just didn't make any soft drinks.

They mothballed the soft drink factory. So after mum and dad passed away, we moved the car rental business over towards the airport and the building sort of fell into a state of disrepair. I suppose if I was writing a valuation report and that's my background commercial real estate, I would have said it was dilapidated, almost in an untenable state.

So after I got back from living overseas, I took on the task of trying to turn the building around. I've thought long and hard about what we should do and I just went back to what the building was

designed to do originally and that was to have drinks production inside it. If you look at the floor carefully, you'll see that from the apex of the floor, there's a slight gradient and that's for wash down and that's really important in brewing because you're always washing down, you're making food, it has to be kept in a hygienic state.

I thought, you know what, let's make a brew pub. We don't have a brew pub, well back then we didn't have any brew pubs in central Queensland and we're just starting to develop those now and we're pretty much still at the pioneering stage in our region for brew pubs. So it's a really exciting time for us.

Now you spent a bit of time in London, you're telling me there for 23 years and you visited quite a few brew pubs in the UK and you brought some of those ideas that you saw over there, over here as well. That's right, I don't remember too much to tell you the truth Geoff. One of the big Aussies in London whooping it up I can imagine.

Yeah, well we certainly, we have pints here and anybody with a bit of a twang with an English or British twang, you know exactly they're going to have a pint. No one's ever going to drink a half. Yeah, I did pick up a lot of things.

The British are experts in bringing old buildings back to a modern state and I suppose I took on my background in commercial real estate and what I'd learnt over there in the refurbishment of this property. Excuse me, I've just got to look after these people, won't be a tick. Okay, no worries.

He's just going to say hello to some people and he'll be back in a moment. Yeah, this is a working brew pub so it's very important that people come in and he's just serving some people so, and it's a very good case of the owner being the actual operator here too, you know, so that's great and we'll be back with him in just a moment. We'll have a listen in and how he does.

You're welcome. So the kitchen's open at 5.30. We can do beers on you. I can do some hot chips if you like something like that.

I like that. Okay, perfect. So the beers are all here.

We've looking for a glass of wine ladies or something like that. We do wine as well. We only sell Queensland products.

So all our wine is Queensland grown and we also have a range of spirits from Bundaberg, Kelki Mountain. I'll grab a lager. A lager? And ladies? As you can see he's very hands-on and he's the owner so it's great that they stock wine from Queensland and other products from Bundaberg and it's very much a North Queensland property here.

The atmosphere to let you know is fantastic. You have giant and if you go on their website you

can see it all and the website is wardsbrewery.com. Very easy to see and you'll see all their lovely stainless steel vats here where they brew everything. They're all in full view here in the venue and they have a very nice relaxing area here where you can and they serve wonderful food here as well.

So we'll be back in just a moment and we'll be chatting some more with the owner Michael Comley of Ward's Brewery here in Gladstone. Well we're back with Michael Comley here at Ward's Brewery and Michael you just served some people some visitors and you were saying behind the bar there that there was you served some Queensland-based wine and other products here as well. Yeah that's right Geoff.

We run with a Queensland artisan liquor license that was brought in about five years ago with the last government and it was to encourage small boutique breweries like ours. Part of the covenant of having that liquor license is that you can only sell Queensland artisan producers products and takeaways you can only sell your own takeaways. You can't set up a bottle shop and sell everybody else's.

So a couple of the restrictions there but it's a great step forward in promoting craft beer and that came out of the Queensland government craft beer report. They could see and identify that there was a lot of employment in craft beer there's a lot of tourism involved in craft beer as well like those people there I just served they've come up from Brisbane. People go up and down the Queensland coast stopping at breweries stopping at wineries.

In our area if we can do beer we don't do wines that well that's more south southeast southwest. So having a Queensland artisan liquor license is also a great thing because I'm dealing direct with the producers. I deal direct with the growers of the grapes from Stanthorpe from around Kingaroy in those areas.

So you're dealing with other like-minded people who have small businesses and it's just fun. You're getting different flavours your customers are getting variety we're not going through the classic standard wholesale so they enjoy it and we often have wine tasting nights in the brewery. And tell us about the process for those who don't know in the brewing system itself from beginning you know from from the beginning you've got the vats here and tell us how it works for people who are interested in this sort of thing.

When I took on this project I couldn't brew a cup of tea. I did course after course I did a couple of courses in brewing just at introduction level just so I could understand the general principles and also the names for the vessels that gave me enough knowledge to get dangerous and go out and invest in the equipment that we have. So we have a 10 heck system it's gas fired it's gas fired from mains gas it's a three vessel system and when I say 10 heck that's 1,000 litres.

So it all starts up in the mill which is up on the platform above the brew house and that's where we crush the malts. The crushed malt is then transferred via that auger into the grist case at the

top of the mash tun where it sits there until we've got all the the crushed malt in there. We'll do a simultaneous drop of the malt and hot water from the hot liquor tank but we need to have a certain strike rate depending on what sort of beer we're going for and we want that strike rate to be bang on so we have burners underneath there so we can keep that temperature quite constant because we want it to be a heterogeneous mix we don't want to clunk up we don't want to ball up and we don't want it to be a a solution that we can't sort of move into the next stage of the louder.

So once we pump that mixture through into the louder it's then rate ever so slightly breaks off the husk so the sugar's in in the malt and is mixed with the water to give out wort w-o-r-t. It's still quite hot but it's not going to be hot enough and then it comes through the biscuit and that is all the husk from the malt and it soaks through there into the false floor and gets pumped through into the kettle whirlpool where it's vigorously boiled and at that point we will put the hops in. Those hops are for bittering it gets up to about 500 degrees that dark chimney going through the roof there that whole process takes around about three and a half hours.

Our vats over on the far side of the brew house area are 1000 and 2000 litre vats so we have to do that process twice if we're doing 2000. We're growing into our brew house so I've purposely acquired a system that's bigger than normal bigger than what you'd initially need and we are growing into it we're growing into it quite fast so yes you'd have to do that process twice. With regard to brewing a bit like what you can see around here I've gone for pretty much everything best in class everything at my affordable rate and that comes down to the brewing process and I went out and hunted and found a fantastic brewer and brought him in from New Zealand.

Paul is in his mid-60s. Paul has been a commercial brewer for a very long time. He has developed some fantastic recipes to the point where in the last two and a half years we've won 19 medals Australia-wide for our beers.

He's in Melbourne this week and we have three beers in the Australian International Beer Awards. There are 2,500 entries from 390 breweries in that competition. I know that we already have one gold medal.

I don't know and that's for our parallel I shouldn't be saying it but yes I do know that because I've been given the heads up already because we're in the mix for something a little bit bigger which if we do pick up a trophy or something like that would be amazing. You can only wish and that's all fantastic in the first two years. Why we go into the competitions and they're professionally judged competitions they're not a popularity contest they are professionally judged there's a standard that you know all the beers have to match to get either a gold or a silver or bronze medal.

We go into it for a number of reasons. First of all so we can get acknowledged as a professional brewery by customers but also by our suppliers so they know that when we're phoning up looking for hops looking for malts they're going to give us a good product. Customers who are driving up

the coast as I said they will go from brewery to brewery and they will have their untapped app or you know just google searching for breweries that are winning awards and they want to go to them.

So that's been really important to us and we're also trying to create a product that our town can be proud of and develop that local community pride and that comes along with our strapline glad it's our beer. That's a wonderful slogan glad it's our beer and that fits in with the Gladstone region completely. It's fantastic that a guy like you a local lad who grew up here who has reacquired something that your parents started and has made it into something so fantastic in the Ward's brewery here in Gladstone.

So if you are coming up to you know taking a drive up and I know a lot of young people do this they do the whole coast all the way up and the oldies do as well. Yes the young the young backpackers and the oldies and I suppose you get a lot of the people in their RVs and stuff their camper vans coming up and they love it too. Nomads everywhere and all you got to do is like make sure that all the salt and all the sugar is all put aside so they don't pick it up and walk out with it.

Exactly because when they're always running out in their vans and everything stick and I know you're very involved with the Gladstone region. That's right well when I relocated back from the UK back into my hometown I was invited to join the South Glaston Roadtree Club which my father was a member of and funny enough the people who lived in the house before my family are also part of that Roadtree Club. It was a great way for me to get back into my own community meet some very interesting people and understand the community I left over 20 odd years ago what the problems are where people are helping and and what's moving in our in our community.

So yeah the Roadtree Club is a fantastic thing we have a big connection with the youth and and the older generations as well here with the work that we do with senior citizens and and the youth so it's just a fantastic thing. It's a really it's quite scary at the moment trying to get people to join establishes not just Roadtree but other voluntary organizations. People seem to have a different value on their personal time they're not sharing it with the community how they used to.

I think you know organizations like Roadtree are still very much struggling to find out how they can continue the great work that they've been doing and it's a real concern actually. Well the Roadtree Club of Australia is fantastic and we'd encourage anybody to get in touch with their local chapters and get in touch. Michael Comley thank you very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia it's been a fascinating insight to the world of brewing.

As we say if you are coming through Gladstone or you live in the Gladstone area please drop in and have Michael pour you a beer. It's a beautiful beautiful ale we're sampling one at the moment which is the Pale Ale. We just won gold medal for it at the Royal Queensland and this is the one I think we're going to get gold medal for at the Australian International Beer Awards and if we do

which I'm pretty sure we will it'll be a massive achievement for my brewer Paul and for me personally of you know being beside him and making this happen.

I'm really proud and I think I think the Gladstone people are very proud of it as well. I certainly are now Michael how can people find out more about you and the brewery online? Well we're on all the social medias you know Instagram, Facebook, Curse of My Life and a lot of other people's not but you've got to be on it right www.wardsbrewery.com that's our website I'm you know looking at it and trying to improve it and we're just trying to improve it at the moment. Facebook, Instagram and www.wardsbrewery.com that's where you can find us at 131 Auckland Street Gladstone Central.

Wards Brewery Gladstone highly recommended by Travel Radio Australia drop in if you are popping by and Michael great to see you thank you very much for being on the program. Thank you Geoff.